FEMINISM IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

International Relations (IR), being a discipline studying the politics among nations within a changing pattern of power relations among them, has been the last of the body of knowledge to be influenced by the feminist perspective. Women have always remained 'hidden' in International Relations, which has been predominantly treated as a masculine discipline. In international politics, men are always in the forefront and women as heads of states or diplomats are hard to find. If one looks at international summits like the G-8 or the UN conferences or conferences and summits of several regional organizations like the European Union or SAARC, the number of men is always greater than the number of women. So, where do we find women in international relations? For long, women have been located as wives of diplomats, wives of politicians or as 'comfort women' for military personnel. But women have always been the victim of decisions taken by men in international politics regarding war and peace. During war or ethnic clashes or separatist movements, they are the worst victims and in the aftermath too, especially if they are forced to leave their country as refugees, their conditions become deplorable. In peace time, women become victims of trafficking, trading in women workers or easy recruits in sex tourist industry flourishing globally. Thus, it is not justified to keep women out of the purview of any sort of discussion in the discourse of International Relations. From the late 1980s and 1990s, attempts were made for re-evaluation of traditional IR theory from the feminist perspectives, which opened up a space for gendering International Relations.

Several conferences and published literature marked a new outlook for examining world events. Jean Bethke Elshtain's *Women and War* (1987), Cynthia Enloe's *Bananas, Beaches and Bases: Making Feminist Sense of International Politics* (1989), J. Ann Tickner's *Gender in International Relations: Feminist Perspectives on Achieving Global Security* (1992), V. Spike Peterson and Anne Sisson Runyan's *Global Gender Issues* (1993), and Christine Sylvester's *Feminist Theory and International Relations in a Postmodern Era* (1994) made their mark in the early 1990s.